

In the mid-1980s, the Chinoy family established the South Seas Distilleries in Dahanu, just a few kilometres away from Behramji's. It has the country's largest copper pot stills and is one of the biggest commercial producers of malts. Sticking to its legacy, it has also been producing mahua for local consumption. Over the years, it has built up stock, all stored in oak barrels. And so it is that the Six Brothers 1922 Resurrection is not only double-distilled in copper pot stills; it is also aged. "Think of it as a fine single malt, since the process is quite similar," says Chinoy.

The mahua flower, also known as mahura or mohua, is native to the Indian subcontinent. It blooms in spring, releasing a strong fragrance and offering a sweet taste due to its high sugar content. It primarily grows in the forests of western, eastern, and central India, and for centuries, a fermented version of it has been consumed by the locals. While it was once cherished by royalty, with a change in tastes and the advent of foreign liquor, it lost its reputation and began being referred to as 'country liquor'. However, efforts are currently underway to alter this perception.

Mumbai's hip new restaurant Bandra Born has launched the country's first mahua bar with 10 mahua-based cocktails along with a variety of classic cocktails. "It's part of India's heritage, and we wanted to promote it. Plus, it's an easy spirit to work with when it comes to cocktails. It's like playing with a sweeter rum," says Chef Partner Gresham Fernandes. Their Kadak Nimbu Sharbat, which is a take on the classic fresh lime soda with kaffir lime and mahua, and the Mahtinez, Bandra Born's take on the classic martini using mahua as the base spirit, are extremely popular, though Fernandes says that guests like having it on the rocks with a twist of lime too.



Bandarful is an artisanal cold-brew coffee liqueur made from single-estate Arabica coffee from Chikkamagaluru

"There's a marked rise in curiosity and willingness to explore among today's consumers, particularly led by the younger Millennials and GenZ... This demand for unique and socially engaging encounters, combined with growing cocktail culture and rising disposable incomes, is driving a new level of experimentation and appreciation of Indian heritage and craft spirits," says Vikram Damodaran, Chief Innovation Officer of Diageo India.

Diageo India recently set up The Good Craft Co., in Bengaluru, its first global initiative to build a direct-to-consumer experiential ecosystem for craft spirits and its makers. In September, the platform opened an experimental lab in the city, called The Flavour Lab, to pro-



vide consumers with an immersion into the art and science behind Indian craft spirits.

Vikram Achanta, Founder & CEO of Tulleeho, a beverage education and consulting service, says: "I for one feel the potential of these spirits is extremely high, not